

Serene Ho

Ph.D. Candidate

Department of Political Science
Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Website: s3reneho.github.io
Email: sereneho@mit.edu

Education

Ph.D. Candidate, Political Science, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Expected 2027

Dissertation: “Heterogeneous Firms and the Politics of Institutional Change”

Committee: In Song Kim (Chair), Kathleen Thelen, F. Daniel Hidalgo

MPA Economic and Political Development, Columbia University, 2018

BEng Mechanical Engineering, Bristol University, United Kingdom, 2010

Research Focus

I study how firms form and act on preferences over labor market institutions, with particular attention to how global economic forces such as trade liberalization and technological change reshape the political coalitions that sustain wage regulation. I use confidential linked employer-employee microdata in the U.S. and causal inference methods to study these questions at the firm level.

Fields of Interest

Labor market institutions, Firm Strategy, Political Economy, Shift-Share designs, Machine Learning, Administrative Microdata, Causal Inference

Papers in Progress

1. The Effect of Trade on Wage Protections: Evidence from Confidential U.S. Census Data on Businesses and Workers.
2. AI Firms and the Politics of Labor: Evidence from Matched Vacancy and Lobbying Data.
3. U.S. Multinationals and Preferential Market Access: Evidence from Confidential U.S. Census Data (with Jingtian Chen, Christine Liu and In Song Kim).

Positions

Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Firms Sector Policy Manager, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), 2018–2020

Summer Research Fellow, MIT Internet Policy Research Initiative, 2017

IMI Precision Engineering Ltd.

Project Manager, 2010–2016.

Research Grants

1. MIT Walter A. Rosenblith Presidential Fellow 2020-2021
2. Columbia School for International and Public Affairs Fellowship 2016-2018

Selected Presentations

- 2019 Keynote Speaker, Innovation Growth Lab (IGL) Winter Research Meeting, Amsterdam, “Overview of Firms Experimental Research”
- 2019 Keynote Speaker, Innovation Growth Lab (IGL) Ph.D. Workshop, Amsterdam, “Into the Wild: The Practicalities of Running Field Experiments”
- 2019 Global Youth Economic Opportunities Summit, Washington, D.C., “Evidence in Business Training for Entrepreneurs: An Interactive Discussion”
- 2019 World Bank J-PAL Firms Seminar Meeting, Washington, D.C., “J-PAL’s Firms Sector and Overview of Firms Research” (with David Atkin)
- 2019 1st Annual Conference of the Private Sector Development Research Network, The Graduate Institute of International and Development Studies, “What an Experimental Research Agenda for Job Creation and Firm Growth Could Look Like” (with David Atkin and Nicholas Bloom)

Teaching Experience

Massachusetts Institute of Technology

- 17.835 Machine Learning and Data Science in Politics (Undergraduate), Fall 2023 (In Song Kim)
Topics: Causal Inference, Linear Regression, Supervised Learning, Unsupervised Learning, Text Analysis, Network Analysis
- 17.800 Quantitative Research Methods (Graduate), Fall 2024 (F. Daniel Hidalgo)
Topics: Probability Theory, Random Variables and Probability Distributions, Linear Regression, Statistical Inference

Columbia University

- U6400 Microeconomic Analysis for International and Public Affairs (Graduate), Fall 2017 (Emmanuel Gerratana)
- U6400 Microeconomic Analysis for International and Public Affairs (Graduate), Spring 2018 (Emmanuel Gerratana)
Topics: Producer and Consumer Theory, Externalities and Public Goods, Non-Competitive Markets, Asymmetric Information, General Equilibrium and Welfare Theorems

Invited Short Courses

- “Education Course in Evaluating Social Programs,” J-PAL, Teaching Assistant, March 2019